Reading Skills

Contents

- Understanding Academic Writing
- Facts and Opinions
- Conclusions and Reasons

What is academic writing?

What is the difference between academic writing and other types of writing?

Following a particular format in structure.

Survey/Research involved.

Producing new questions and ideas.







What is academic English?

Academic English is the type of English used in the world of research, study, teaching and universities. It is also generally referred to as EAP, English for Academic Purposes.





What is academic writing?

What is the difference between academic writing and other types of writing?

Read the following two paragraphs and compare their writing styles to find the differences.



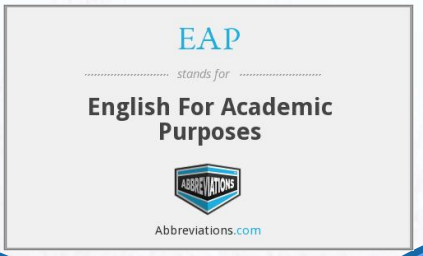


What is academic writing?

■ Features of academic writing

1. It uses formal academic language and avoids colloquialisms.
2. It usually avoids “I” and is written in the third person and
   often uses impersonal structures.
3. It often uses the passive voice.
4. There are well developed paragraphs which often start with a strong topic sentence.
7. There are lots of references to other writers.
8. The texts are well structured.

What is academic English?



EAP

Context reduced

Critical thinking

Information

Content oriented

General English

Context embedded

Social communication

Role play

Task oriented

EAP: English for Academic Purposes

Format of Academic Writing

The major components of an academic research paper:

1. Introduction
2. Methods
3. Results
4. Disscussions

➡ **IMRD**

Text Reading

- **Understanding Introduction**
- Key words:

Words that most frequently occur in an academic paper and are mostly related to the core research of the paper.

- Laypeople; Understanding; Radioactivity; Radiation

Text Reading-Introduction

- Research objective

Function:

Report the purpose for conducting the research.

Text Reading-Methods

- Methods:

The tool that is used in the research to find out new substance, new ideology, new conceptions, or rules.

e.g. observation; survey; investigation; behavioral study; comparative study; historical approach.

Facts vs. Opinions P.233

To determine the validity of an argument, we must distinguish between facts and opinions.

- **A fact is a statement that can be shown to be true by observation or experiment.**

➢ George Washington was the first president of the United States.

Facts vs. Opinions

- **An opinion is a statement of personal feeling or a judgment. It is something believed to exist, but it only reflects a belief or an interpretation of facts and varies among people.**

  - George Washington was the best president of the United States.
  - Opinions include: ideas, arguments, claims, and hypotheses.

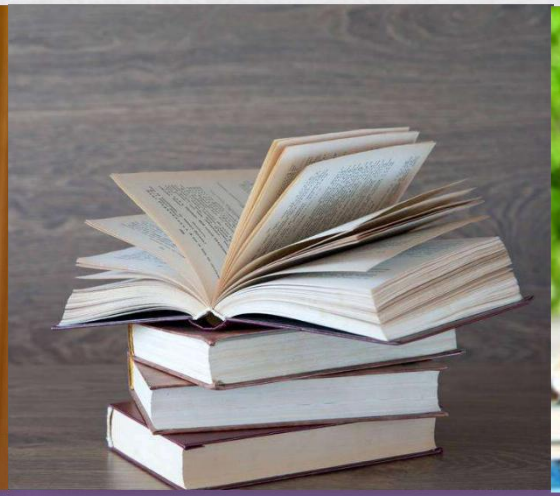
Identifying Conclusions and Reasons

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Conclusions and Reasons (P. 61)

Are major components of an argument.

A good conclusion is based on a sound reason, but most importantly, it is based on a valid premise.


Academic Writing

Contents

- Choosing a Topic
- Searching for Sources
- Writing a Literature Review and an Introduction
- Writing a Methods Section
- Writing a Results Section
- Writing a Discussion Section
- Writing an Abstract

Choosing a Topic

- Deciding on a main topic
- Narrowing down the topic
- Formulating research questions
- Writing a working title

Deciding on a Main Topic

How to Choose a Topic which is possible to research? (P. 26)

- Adequate
- Important
- Manageable



Choose a topic that is ADEQUATE

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- Has the topic I am going to choose been researched in previous studies?
- Investigations on the previous literature is important for gathering your own materials.





Choose a topic that is IMPORTANT

- Does my research has academic and social value?
- The topic you choose should be problem-orientated.





Choose a topic that is MANAGEABLE

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- Is my research too broad to carry out?
- A more specific topic can be more manageable and simpler for starters to research in.





Narrowing down a Topic

Main topics need to be narrowed down.

- **In order to make your topic manageable, limitations need to be added to the main topic to narrow it down.**

- **Possible limitations:**

1. regional limitations

e.g. nations, cities, universities …

2. topical limitations

e.g. effects, causes, sub-matters, solutions …

3. group limitations

e.g. students, researchers, nationalities, certain gender/age/profession …

Formulating Research Questions

How to formulate research questions? (P. 28)

- **An appropriate, specific topic is determined by your research questions.**
- **A research question is a statement that identifies the focus of your topic.**
- **It is the question that your project or your paper wants to answer.**

Formulating Research Questions

A research question serves two purposes:

- **It identifies the specific objectives your project or your paper will address.**
- **It determines the size of your research or the length of your paper.**

Raising research questions will make your topic specific, more tangible and more focused.

Formulating Research Questions

Tips on formulating research questions

- **Research questions should be complete and specific.**
- **Avoid using yes no questions alone.**
- **Research questions should be possible to answer based on your research design.**
- **Research questions should set accurate research size.**

What is a “working title”?

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The title you think of initially for the project or paper which you are going to write. It may be changed as you carry out research and become more involved in the subject of your project.

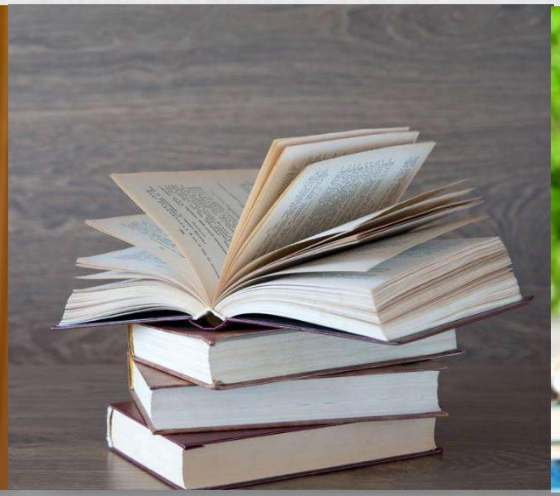




What is a good title?

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- It should indicate the topic of the study by using the key words about contents and methods.
- It should indicate the scope of the study.
- It should be self-explanatory to readers in the chosen area.
- Sometimes it summarizes the results.


What is a good title?

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method words + content words + limiting words

method words:

Comparison, analysis, contrast, investigation, discussion, explanation, study, assessment...





What is a good title?

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method words + content words + limiting words

content words:

health risks, somkers, reseach report, computer hackers, lung cancer, nuclear power plant, energy...





What is a good title? (p.30)

method words + content words + limiting words

limiting words:

causes, effects, adavantages, benefits, effectiveness...



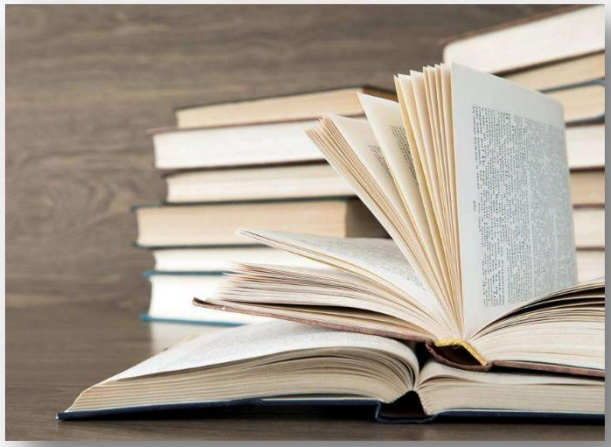


Searching for Sources

Sources are any information which you take from books, journal articles, reports, government documents, conference proceedings, Web resources and lectures.

There are two types of sources:

- Primary (original)
- Secondary

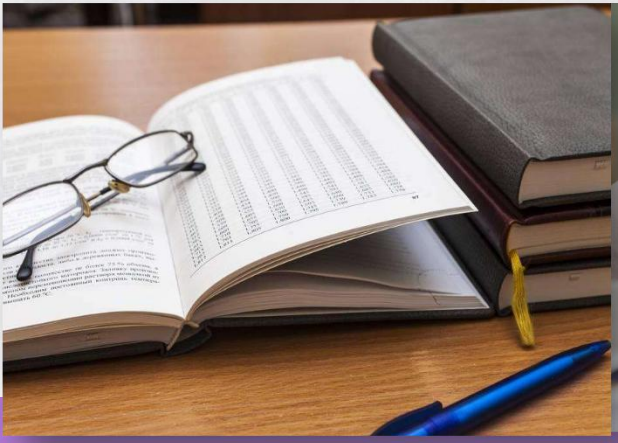


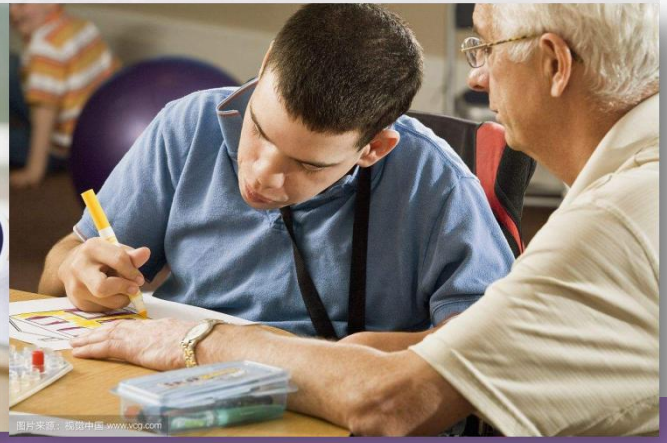
Searching for Sources

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Original/Primary Sources

Documents, reports, recordings, or other sources of information that are created most probably through first-hand surveys, investigations, experiments and field studies.





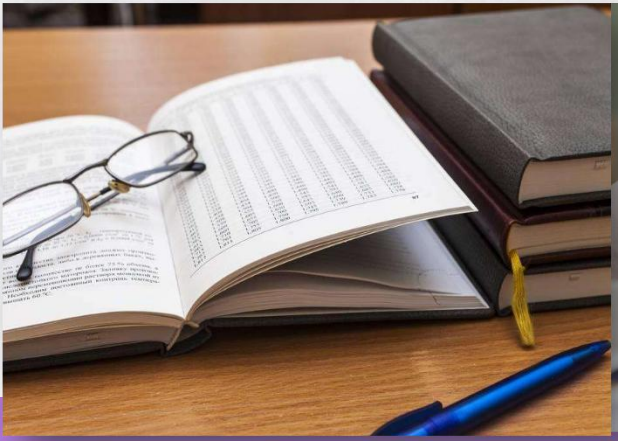
Searching for Sources

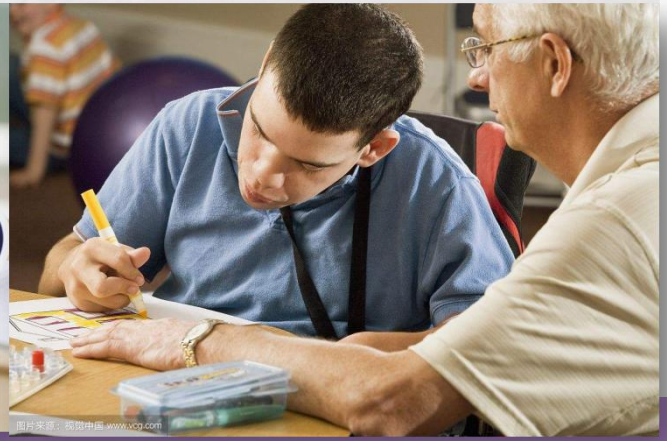
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Secondary Sources

Cite, comment on, or build upon primary sources.

For example, textbooks and literature reviews.



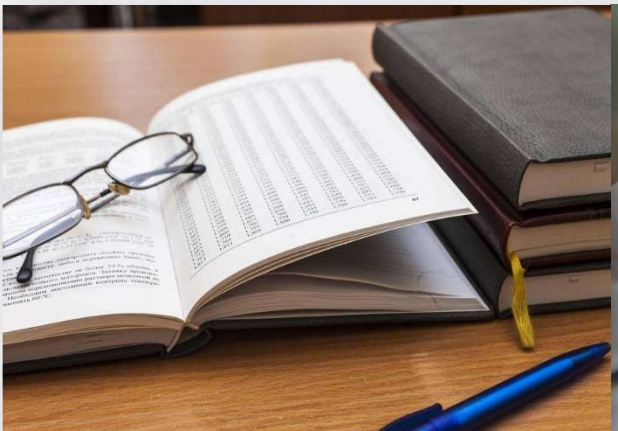


Searching for Sources

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General methods for searching for sources:

- Using the term as key words in electronic searches or library searches;
- Locating potentially appropriate and relevant sources (titles, contents, introductions, abstracts);
- Reading them quickly and decide which ones are most relevant to your topic;
- Evaluating the usefulness and reliability by comparing and contrasting those sources.





Searching for Sources

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Evaluating various sources

There are various sources available, you must evaluate them. You can ask questions:

- **Is the material a primary or a secondary source?**
- **Is the source the latest one?**
- **Does the source seem strongly biased?**
- **Are the authors arguments supported by reliable evidence?**
- **Who is the publisher? What reputation does the publisher have?**

Searching for Sources

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Evaluating various sources

There are three rules of evaluating a reliable source:

- The time rule

The closer in time, the better the source will be. The latest source materials will give new information and results of your topic.

- The bias rule

It is said that every source is biased in some way. Choose unbiased sources which are more trustworthy.

- The experts rule

Choose the sources created by the authors who are the authorities of a certain field and whose works are frequently cited.

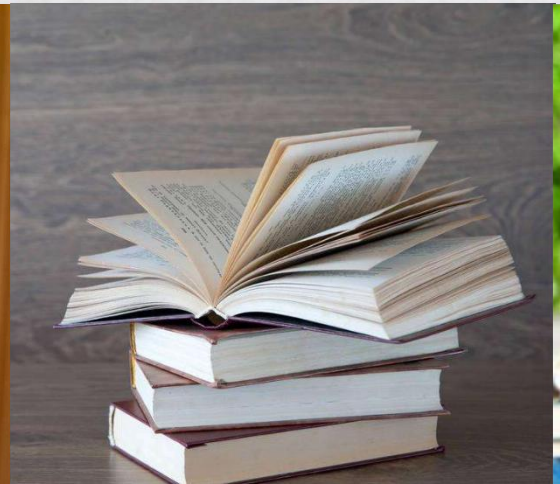
Understanding a Literature Review P.114

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What Is a Literature Review?

It is an overview of the current state of research on a particular topic by evaluating and comparing various previous studies related to the topic.

- It is built on the work of earlier authors.
- It reveals controversies, arguments and even weaknesses or gaps in current work.

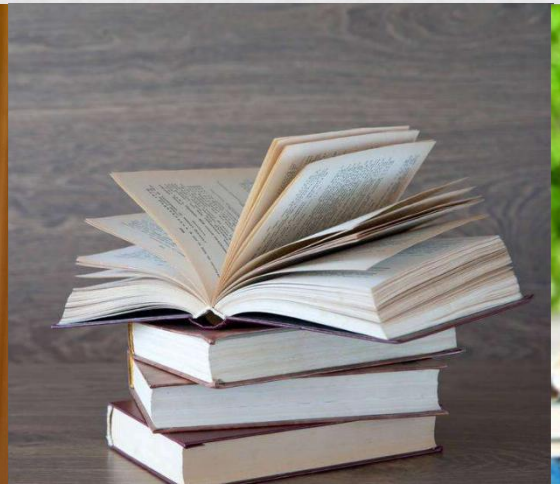

Understanding a Literature Review

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Two Types of Literature Reviews

1. A self-contained literature review

- It summarizes multiple previous studies so that the readers will be informed of the consensus, debates and unanswered questions concerning the topic.

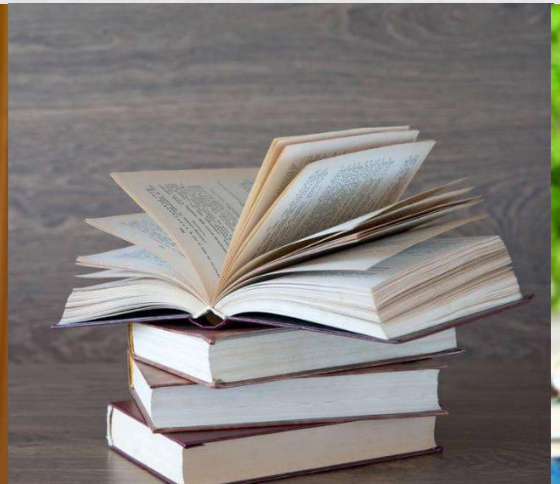

Understanding a Literature Review

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Two Types of Literature Reviews

2. A part of an introduction.

- It reports the previous studies and attempts to find their weaknesses or limitations.
- It tells the readers that the present study will be more rational, useful, significant and valid.
- It is often incorporated into the introduction section.

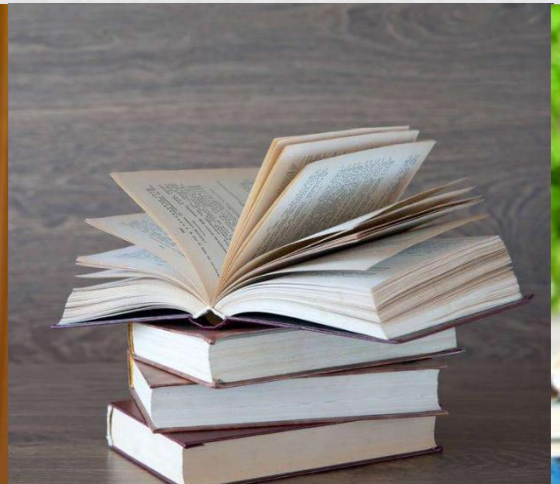

Understanding a Literature Review

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Organization of a Literature Review

Organizing and present the sources in a logical way.

- Chronological review: organized in order of their publication.
- Thematic review: organized in terms of themes or topics.


Writing a Good Literature Review

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A good LR is composed of 3 parts.

- An introduction (providing the background of your topic and indicating the objective of your review);
- A body paragraph (having a clear classification and sythesis of the information gathered either in a chronological way or a thematic way);
- A conclusion (giving a summary of);
  1. the main agreements and disagreements
  2. the gap or area for further research
  3. your overall perspective on the topic
  4. your further research

Using Appropriate Tenses in LRs

- The simple past tense is often used in LRs to refer to the findings of previous studies);

Example

Kemp (1992) found that his subjects responded poorly to the lecturing style of teaching.





Using Appropriate Tenses in LRs

- The present perfect tense may be preferable in some cases (p.122);
  1. the research referred to is recent, or indicate the present sate of knowledge.
  2. there is no specific date you can refer to
  3. when summarizing an area of research
  4. when referring to comparing positions in a debate which is still going on





Using Appropriate Tenses in LRs

Example

Although students in the past primarily focused strictly on educational content, most resent research has found that in the classrooms of today, students are more concerned about social issues than academic issues.

These studies have revealed that there is a gap in the research about …





Using Appropriate Tenses in LRs

- The simple present tense is often used when referring to the ideas, findings and conclusions of the works written a long time ago, which indicates that the work is so influential on current thinking);

Example

Dewey's philosophy of education is that an experience-based curriculum promotes more effective learning and a greater competence in living.





Writing an Introduction Section P.123

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The introduction section

Is the start of a research article.

The main purpose of an introduction is to give background information about the topic of the paper, and set out the specific questions to be addressed by the author.

An introduction usually includes the following elements:







Writing an Introduction Section

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- Introduce you topic and provide relevant background information;
- Give clear definitions of the key terms;
- Review the previous studies and point out limitations;
- State the purpose of your study and set out research questions;
- Introduce the theoretical perpectives or/and the method to be used.
- Explain the outline of the paper.





Writing a Methods Section (P.158)

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What is a Methods Section?

The methods section provides the technical details of how a study is conducted or how data are collected to answer a research question or test a hypothesis







Writing a Methods Section

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What are the general types of data collection?

- By experiment: an orderly procedure carried out with the goal of verifying, refuting, or establishing the validity of a hypothesis.





Writing a Methods Section

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What are the general types of data collection?

- By survey: a standardized paper-and-pencil, phone or computerized questionnaire that asks predetermined questions.





Writing a Methods Section

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What are the general types of data collection?

- By interview: a structured or unstructured one-on-one directed conversation with key individuals or leaders in the community.

- The methods section serves as a “how-to” manual if you are interested in carrying out an experiment or a survey.





Writing a Methods Section

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What does the methods section include?

- **Participants**
  - The participants in your study;
  - The way you chose the participants;
  - Any restrictions in the nature of your participant pool.





Writing a Methods Section

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What does the methods section include?

- **Materials**
  - It tells the readers what equipment and tools you used to run your experiments or surveys and to acquire data.





Writing a Methods Section

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What does the methods section include?

- **Procedure**
  - It gives the reader a summary of each step in the execution of the research.
  - The summary must be concise, precise, and logical.





Controlling Variables

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Types of variables

- Dependent variables

A dependent variable is the event under study and is expected to change with changes in the independent variable.

It is dependent on the independent variable, and often represents outcome of the experiment.





Controlling Variables

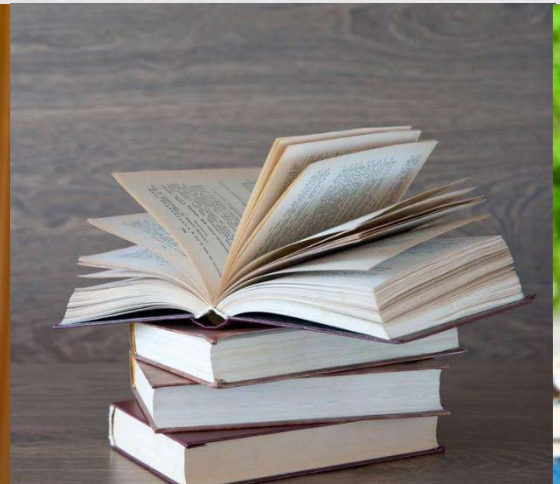
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Types of variables

- Independent variables

An independent variable is a variable whose value does not depend on another variable.

It often causes the dependent variable to change and is the input of the experiment.


Controlling Variables

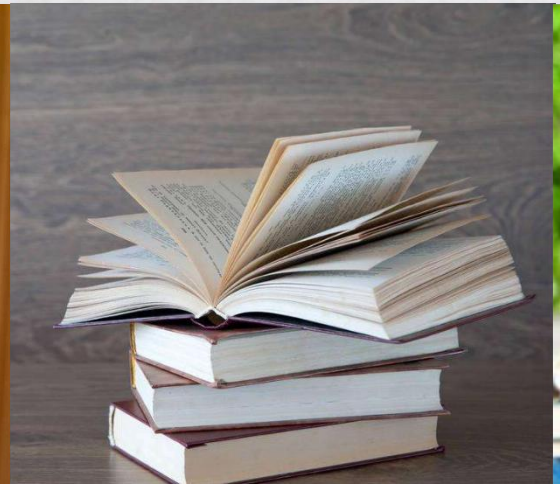
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Types of variables

- Controlled variables

A controlled variable is the experimental element which is constant and unchanged throughout the course of the investigation.

It can also cause the change of the dependent variables, and is expected to be controlled.


Writing a Results Section (Page 166)

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What is a results section?

The results section is the real meat of a primary research article.

- It reports the data from the experiments;
- It highlights key findings from the data;
- It rounds figures and makes generalized comparisons





Writing a Results Section

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The general guidelines for the results section:

1. Do not give detailed methods.
2. Do not list data.
3. Do not repeat the detail.
4. Select and highlight the main data which can directly answer the research questions raised in the introduction section.
5. Do not offer the description of the data without an opening sentence which summarizes the findings derived from the data.

Writing a Results Section

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Using tables and figures effectively

Tables are used to make an article more readable by removing numeric data from the text.

Figures provide visual impacts and therefore they are often the best way to communicate the primary findings.





Writing a Results Section

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Some suggestions on using data and tables

1. Limit the number of tables and figures and only illustrate results that are relevant to the research questions, and that could not be presented adequately in the text.
2. Write a descriptive title for each table and figure.
3. Number each table and figure in the order in which they are referred to.
4. Place the tables, figures and graphs at the attached appendices if they may interrupt reading.
5. Be sure all the tables and figures are referred to.

Writing a Results Section

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Using correct tenses in reporting results

- Two tenses are often used.
- Simple present are used for reporting verbs, while the simple past is used to report content.

- For example:

  Table 1 shows the gap between what the respondents thought and what they actually practiced.

Writing a Discussion Section (Page 198)

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What is a discussion section?

The discussion section discusses the issues arising from findings of your research because your results make little sense to most readers without interpretation.







Writing a Discussion Section (Page 198)

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Discussion answers the following questions

- Do the data support your hypotheses or answer your research questions?
- Are your results consistent with what other investigators have reported?
- Can your offer explanations for your findings?
- What are the theoretical or practical implications of your findings?
- What are the suggestions pertaining to the problems?
- What direction should further research on the topic make?

Writing a Discussion Section (Page 198)

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Discussion should:

- Restate the major findings;
- Compare your results with those of previous studies;
- Explain your findings, especially the unexpected findings;
- Discuss the implications of your findings;







Writing An Abstract (Page 207)

What is an abstract?

An abstract is a single paragraph (about 200 words) , which gives the reader a “previw” of the whole academic paper.





Writing An Abstract (Page 207)

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Why is abstract important?

The abstract is more important for the readers than teh writer, because it is the only part of the paper that is published in conference proceedings.

Nowadays many abstracts are published separately in biblographical sources so that potential readers can quickly find your paper through elctronic databases.







Writing An Abstract (Page 207)

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Types of abstracts:

- Paper abstracts
- Conference abstracts

Information included:

- background of the study
- research objectives
- methods employed
- important finding or results obtained
- conclusions drawn

Task 1 P. 208

Using Correct Tenses in Abstracts (P.213)

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The present and present perfect tenses

Example

- This paper discusses the use of a virtual experimentation environment as a planning and training tool for machining processes.
- Breast-feeding, a traditional infant-feeding practice in Nageria, has undergone a serious decline recently.





Using Correct Tenses in Abstracts (P.213)

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The simple past tense is used when reporting methods and results.

Example

- A group of female rats were fed with GM flour before mating and preganancy.
- The survey revealed incomplete understanding of concepts such as radioactive decay, half-life and absorption of radiation.







Using Correct Voice and Language (P. 213)

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Passive voice is often used when reporting the method, data, subject, procedures and findings.

Example

- A questionair survey was conducted to examing non-experts' conceptions of radiation.
- The weight and the mortality rate of the newborn pups were analyzed.







Literacy Skills

Contents

- Avoiding Plagiarism
  - Quoting
  - Paraphrasing
  - Summarizing
  - Synthesizing
- Writing in a Formal Style
- Reporting Verbs
- Transitional Language
- Hedging Language

Avoiding Plagiarism (p.33)

What is plagiarism?

- a kind of theft, referring to the use of other's findings, arguments, data, and words without appropriate citation or referencing a published or unpublished source.
- 3 other definitions (Task 2)

Citation (p.34)

What is citation?

- to provide evidence and exemplification from sources to support an argument

Why is it necessary to use citation?

- to give definition, introduce theories, describe previous studies, give examples, etc.

3 citation methods

- quoting
- paraphrasing
- summarizing

Citation (p.34)

2 components for referencing

- In-text referencing
- End-of-text referencing

What is “et al”?

- Latin for “and others”(if more than 3 authors)

- Exercise: Identify the citations and in-text references used in Task on Page. 35.

Quoting (p.36)

What is quoting?

- To quote words, sentences and paragraphs directly from original texts.

2 versions of quoting

- Author-focused version
- Information-focused version

2 scenarios of quoting

- Placing quotation marks
- Indenting the text as a block

Quoting

- How to quote a text?

1. Put quotation marks around quoted material.

2. Put the author's last name(s) in the brackets after the quoting.



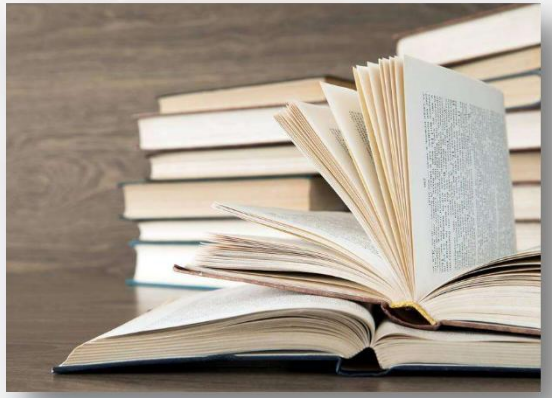
3. Put the year of the publication after the author's name(s).

4. Put a period outside parenthesis.

Paraphrasing P.85

Paraphrase is a restatement of the meaning of a sentence or a text using your own words.

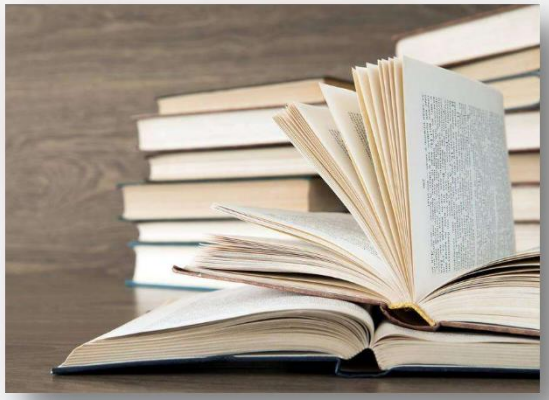
- **Words and grammatical structures changed (a sequence of three words will not be the same of the original)**
- **Ideas in the original information should not be changed.**
- **Ideas not removed or added.**
- **Nearly the same length as the original.**



Dealing with the shared language

- Certain kinds of words and phrases need not be changed as they can be shared by both the original and your paraphrase.

- **Proper nouns such as names of people, organizations, places, etc…;**
- **Common nouns that are difficult to reword efficiently;**
- **Technical terms;**
- **Numbers and dates.**



Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

The scientists' experiment produced an unexpected result.

Paraphrase

The scientists' experiment generated an unexpected outcome.

■ Using Synonyms in paraphrasing.

Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

The researchers divided the participants into three groups randomly.

Paraphrase

The respondents were randomly divided into three groups.

■ Using the passive/active voice in paraphrasing.

Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

Obviously, different people have different attitudes toward mental illness.

Paraphrase

Evidently, attitudes toward mental illness vary from person to person.

■ Using different order in paraphrasing.

Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

Many influences can be taken into consideration and many other factors affect global temperatures.

Paraphrase

No single influence can be taken into isolation and many other factors affect global temperatures.

■ Using the negative or positive structure in paraphrasing.

Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

Note-taking is a very important skill for reading and listening to lectures.

Paraphrase

Being skillful at note-taking is of great importance to the readers and lecture listeners.

■ Using different parts of speech in paraphrasing.

Practising Paraphrasing

➢ Specific methods for paraphrasing:

Original

People are increasingly interested in natural foods which do not contain chemical addictives.

Paraphrase

Interest has grown in natural foods: foods which do not contain chemical addictives.

■ Using impersonal structure / nonminalisation in paraphrasing.

The Use of Nominalization

Nominalization is common in academic writing in that the action is more important than the agent of the action. It can:

1. **create an impersonal and objective tone;**
2. **Increase the density of meaning and conciseness of expression.**

The Use of Nominalization

For Example:

- **Men were reluctant to retire, because they anticipate that they would be deprived of money rather than work.**
- Reluctance among men to retire was associated with anticipated deprivations, mainly of money rather than of work.
- **If we do not recognize the serious problem of growing population, we will make a big mistake.**
- Failure to recognize the seriousness of growing population will lead to a big mistake.

Summarizing (p.38)

What is summarizing?

- To express the same idea in a smaller number of words.

Why is summarizing important?

- Help you better understand text
- Support your own view

2 kinds of summaries

- Global (to summarize the whole text)
- Specific (to summarize the parts)

Summarizing (p.38)

Rules of summarizing:

- Focus: include only the most important ideas.
- Paraphrasing: no more than 4 words in a row taken directly from the original text.
- Length: noticeably shorter than the original

Summarizing (p.38)

Steps of summarizing-1:

- Read intensively
- Highlight topic and concluding sentences.
- Identify the key points.
- Make notes by paraphrasing.
- Organize the points into a sentence.
- Check your work.
- Provide a reference.

Summarizing a Passage

Steps of summarizing-2:

- Read the whole passage intensively;
- Highlight topic and concluding sentences in each paragraph;
- Make notes by paraphrasing the topic sentences;
- Organize the paraphrased sentences into a coherent paragraph by adding transitional words;
- Check your work and provide a reference.

Synthesizing

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Tips on writing a good synthesis.

- Find relevant sources;
- Read actively to find connections among different sources;
- Summerize the relevant content in each source;
- Put together the summaries into a coherent text under a topic sentence which can summerize all the information;
- Acknowledge the sources.

Writing in a Formal Style P. 172



The objective of academic writing is to inform rather than entertain.



An academic essay is characterized by objectivity and preciseness.



To achieve the purpose, formality is an important element of a research paper.

Writing in a Formal Style

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Use academic and formal words.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - Several bad effects have been found in the study.

    bad ---- negative





Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid using too many phrasal expressions.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - The low family income speed up the negative change of infant-feeding practice.

speed up ---- accelerate





Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid using general and vague words or expressions.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:
  - The major things that contribute to the results are objective reasons.

things ---- factors





Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid the use of the first and second person pronouns.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentences:
  - It been well established that your physical conditions will be affected by the use of GM foods..

    your ---- people's
  - I have distributed 384 questionnaires to undergraduate students.

    I ---- researchers/experimenters

Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid contractions; use the full form.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:
  - It's positive that the infant-feeding practice is seriously affected by women's family conditions.

It's ---- It is





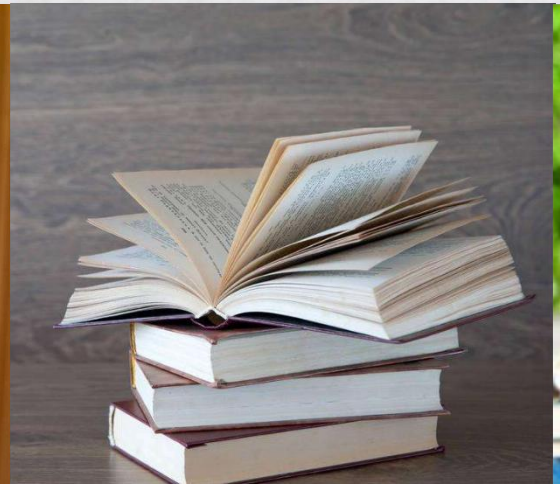
Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid personal and emotional expressions.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:
  - It is surprising for the researchers that large number of these women have expressed a longer ideal duration of breast-feeding.

surprising ---- unexpected


Writing in a Formal Style

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Do not start a sentence with coordinating conjunctions.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:
  - And more variables have been considered in this research.

And ---- Meanwhile





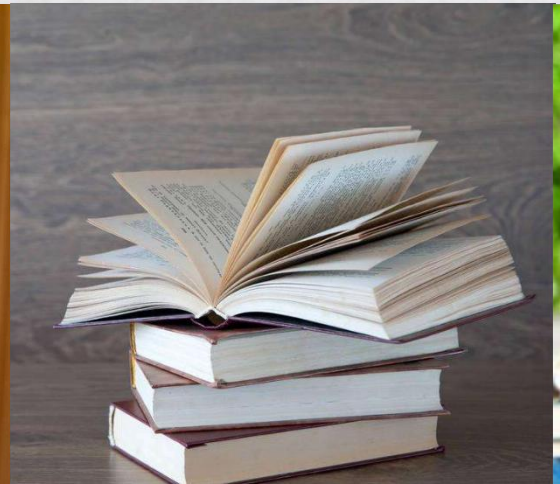
Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid rhetorical questions.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:
  - How can we engage students in learning?

There are several practical strategies to engage students in learning.


Writing in a Formal Style

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When listing items, avoid using etc. or and so on.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - There are many causes of student exhaustion, such as poor diet, part-time work, and so on.

There are many causes of student exhaustion, such as poor diet, part-time work and stress.

Writing in a Formal Style

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Use conjunctions and signpost expressions to introduce new sections.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - Speaking of the question of the general attitudes towards GM food, the results of this research indicated certain interpretations.

    Turning to the question of the general attitudes towards GM food, the results of this research indicated certain interpretations.

Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid using a series of short sentences.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - There were three groups for the participants. The participants were randomly assigned to one of the groups. Each of the groups had a different level of reward.

The participants were randomly assigned to one of the three groups, each of which had a different level of reward.

Writing in a Formal Style

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Avoid clichés and idioms.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - Although the results indicated negative changes, there is still silver lining.

    Although the results indicated negative changes, there is still possibilities for a positive turning.

Writing in a Formal Style

Try to use nominalization instead of verbs.

- Find out the inappropriate wording in the following sentence:

  - The audience believed that using cleaning products affected the environment negatively.

The belief of the audience was that the use of cleaning products had a negative effect on the environment.

Reporting verbs? P. 136

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Reporting verbs are a way for you, the writer, to show your attitudes towards the source of information you are citing.

They can state the author's ideas in the following ways:

- **Neutral**
- **Showing the author's attitude**
- **Giving information about the author's work**
- **Highlighting the author's viewpoint**
- **Reporting the author's results**

A Note on Transitional Language

Transitional language

- It refers to words and phrases which contribute to the understanding of ideas as well as to the coherence of the writing.
- There are several categories according to their semantic meaning:

A Note on Transitional Language

- **Illustration:** to provide examples;
- **Cause:** to give reasons;
- **Effect:** to reveal the outcome;
- **Comparison:** to compare similar conditions;
- **Contrast:** to establish contrasting conditions;
- **Listing:** to list items;
- **Condition:** to provide prerequisites;
- **Classification:** to put items into categories;
- **Summary:** to conclude ideas.

Exercise on Summarizing -3

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Types	Transitional Phrases and Words
Illustration	For example, for instance, in particular
Cause	Because, owing to, due to, on account of
Effect	Therefore, as a result, consequently, so
Comparison	In comparison, similarly, likewise
Contrast	However, nevertheless, on the other hand, by contrast
Listing	To begin with, in the first place, then, furthermore, second, finally, moreover
Classification	One category/feature is, can be classified/divided into,
Summary	To sum up, to conclude, in brief
Condition	If, unless, assuming that

Using Correct Voice and Language (P. 213)

Hedging Language

- Chances are you may miss some information or evidence that you have not found, and that perhaps there are flaws in your claims, or that there may be exceptions to the conclusion you have drawn.
- To protect yourself from possible criticism, you need to use hedging language.







Using Correct Voice and Language (P. 213)

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Hedging Language

Example

- However, our survey seems to suggest that fraud might be more prevalent in epidemiological studies than in clinical trials. A possible explanatin for this finding may be the more controlled nature of the clinical trial, which makes it less amenable to fraud.

- Unemployment causes crime. (strong)
- Unemployment tend to cause crime. (moderate)
- Unemployment may cause crime. (weak)